# London Travel Guide

*Royal history and modern culture on the River Thames - United Kingdom*

## London: Overview and History

London is the capital of England and the United Kingdom and sits on the River Thames. The Romans founded the city as Londinium around AD 47, making London, like Paris and Barcelona, a former town of the Roman Empire ruled from Rome. Parts of the old Roman wall can still be seen near Tower Hill.

In 1666 the Great Fire of London destroyed much of the medieval city. The architect Sir Christopher Wren then rebuilt dozens of churches, including the famous St Paul's Cathedral with its great dome. In the nineteenth century London became the capital of the British Empire and the largest city in the world.

British traders also founded cities far away. In 1819 Sir Stamford Raffles of the British East India Company established a trading post that became Singapore, and in 1788 the British First Fleet arrived in Sydney. London therefore has historical links with both Singapore and Sydney.

Today London is a global centre of finance, theatre, music and museums. It hosted the Summer Olympic Games three times, in 1908, 1948 and 2012, more than any other city.

# London: Top Attractions

The Tower of London, founded by William the Conqueror in 1066, has served as a royal palace, prison and treasury. It still guards the Crown Jewels, watched over by the Yeoman Warders known as Beefeaters. Next to it, Tower Bridge opens to let tall ships pass along the Thames.

Buckingham Palace is the London home of the British monarch. The Changing of the Guard ceremony takes place outside the palace on several mornings each week. Nearby, Westminster Abbey has hosted coronations since 1066, and the Houses of Parliament are crowned by the clock tower known as Big Ben (officially the Elizabeth Tower).

Many of London's best museums are free. The British Museum displays the Rosetta Stone and the Egyptian mummies, the Natural History Museum has a giant blue whale skeleton, and Tate Modern shows modern art inside a former power station on the South Bank.

For views, ride the London Eye, a giant observation wheel opposite Parliament, or go up The Shard, the tallest building in the UK. In the West End you can see world-famous musicals and plays.

# London: Neighborhoods and Food

Covent Garden is known for its market hall, street performers and the Royal Opera House. Nearby Soho is full of restaurants, bars and nightlife. Camden is famous for its alternative fashion stalls and Camden Market, while Notting Hill is known for its colourful houses and the Portobello Road antiques market.

Shoreditch in East London is a creative district of street art, galleries and coffee shops. Brick Lane, close by, is the centre of London's Bangladeshi community and is famous for curry and for bagel bakeries that are open 24 hours.

Classic British dishes include fish and chips, the full English breakfast, and the Sunday roast with Yorkshire pudding, served in traditional pubs. Afternoon tea with scones, clotted cream and jam is a famous London treat in grand hotels such as The Ritz.

Borough Market, near London Bridge, is one of the oldest and best food markets in the city, with stalls selling cheese, street food and baked goods. In restaurants a service charge of 12.5 percent is often added to the bill.

# London: Getting Around and Practical Tips

The London Underground, known as the Tube, opened in 1863 and is the oldest underground railway in the world. Visitors can tap in and out with a contactless bank card or an Oyster card, and daily fares are automatically capped. Red double-decker buses are a cheap way to see the city.

Heathrow Airport is the busiest airport in the UK. The Heathrow Express train reaches Paddington station in about 15 minutes, and the Elizabeth line is a cheaper option. London also has Gatwick, Stansted, Luton and London City airports. Emirates flies from Dubai to Heathrow and Gatwick, and flights from New York to London take about 7 hours.

The Eurostar train leaves from St Pancras International and reaches Paris Gare du Nord in about 2 hours and 15 minutes, so a trip to Paris is easy to add.

The currency in London is the pound sterling (GBP). The best time to visit is from May to September when days are long and parks are green, but it can rain at any time of year, so carry an umbrella.

# London: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Visit Westminster Abbey, Big Ben and the Houses of Parliament, walk through St James's Park to Buckingham Palace, and ride the London Eye at sunset. Day 2: Explore the Tower of London and Tower Bridge, walk along the South Bank to Tate Modern, and finish at Borough Market.

Day 3: Spend the morning at the British Museum, shop in Covent Garden, and see a West End show in the evening.

Popular day trips include Windsor Castle, the oldest occupied castle in the world, about an hour away. The university city of Oxford is about one hour by train. Bath is famous for its Roman Baths, and Stonehenge is a prehistoric stone circle on Salisbury Plain.

Thanks to the Eurostar, London is easily combined with Paris, and its large airports make it a convenient stopover between New York, Dubai and Singapore.